PRINTABLE KIT · 14 PAGES

FOR ADULT CHILDREN OF AGING PARENTS

The First 30 Days

A caregiver's starter kit for the month after you realize a parent needs your help. One page for each thing that keeps you up at night, in the order you'll need them.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- How to use this kit
- 30-day roadmap, week by week
- Emergency fridge sheet
- Care team & contacts
- Current medication list
- Weekly medication log
- Appointment tracker
- Questions to ask the doctor
- Important documents checklist
- Daily care & symptom log
- Home safety walkthrough
- Weekly caregiver check-in
- Call & decision log

START HERE

How to use this kit

You don't have to do all of this at once. The roadmap on the next page spreads it across four weeks. Print what you need, when you need it.

Print once

- [ ] Emergency fridge sheet
  Fill it in first. Tape it to the fridge and keep a photo on your phone.
- [ ] Care team & contacts
- [ ] Current medication list
  Reprint whenever a medication changes.
- [ ] Important documents checklist
- [ ] Home safety walkthrough
- [ ] 30-day roadmap

Print weekly or as needed

- [ ] Weekly medication log
  One sheet per week. Five copies covers the month.
- [ ] Weekly caregiver check-in
  Sunday night, five minutes, for you.
- [ ] Daily care & symptom log
  Use it when something feels off, or daily if a doctor asked you to watch for changes.
- [ ] Appointment tracker
  Bring it to every visit.
- [ ] Questions to ask the doctor
  Fill it in the night before a visit.
- [ ] Call & decision log

Three habits that make the rest easier

1. Keep one binder. Everything from this kit goes in one place, in this order. When another family member steps in, you hand them the binder, not a phone call.

2. Write down every call. Insurance, pharmacy, the doctor's office. Date, who you spoke to, what they said. The call log at the back exists because you will be asked "who told you that?"

3. Bring the medication list everywhere. Every provider will ask. A current list in your hand is the single most useful thing you can carry into an appointment or an emergency room.

This binder is for

Kept by (primary caregiver)

This kit is an organizer. It helps you record and track information so you can share it accurately with your parent's doctors, pharmacist, and family. It is not medical, legal, or financial advice. For decisions about care, medications, or legal documents, talk with the professionals involved in your parent's care.

THE PLAN

30-day roadmap

Four weeks, one focus each. Check things off as you go. If a week slips, it slips. The order matters more than the pace.

Week 1 · Stabilize

Make sure anyone who walks in the door can keep your parent safe.

- [ ] Fill in the emergency fridge sheet and tape it up
- [ ] Build the current medication list (bottles in hand, not from memory)
- [ ] Fill in care team & contacts
- [ ] Confirm the pharmacy and set up refill reminders
- [ ] Start the weekly medication log
- [ ] Save the primary doctor's after-hours number in your phone

Week 2 · Paperwork

Find out what exists before you need it in a hurry.

- [ ] Work through the important documents checklist
- [ ] Locate insurance cards, Medicare card, photo ID; photograph both sides
- [ ] Ask whether a healthcare power of attorney and advance directive exist
- [ ] Ask the doctor's office which release form lets them talk to you
- [ ] List recurring bills and how each one is paid

Week 3 · Care team & routine

Turn a crisis into a schedule.

- [ ] Book or confirm the next appointment with every current provider
- [ ] Fill in "Questions to ask the doctor" before the first visit
- [ ] Write down the daily routine: meals, meds, sleep, activity
- [ ] Decide who does what among family; write names next to tasks
- [ ] Ask the doctor's office what to watch for and when to call
- [ ] Start the daily care log if anything is being monitored

Week 4 · Home, money, and you

The things that go wrong quietly.

- [ ] Do the home safety walkthrough, room by room
- [ ] Fix the three cheapest, highest-risk items first
- [ ] Set up the call & decision log as your running record
- [ ] Ask what local help exists: Area Agency on Aging, senior center, respite care
- [ ] Do your first weekly caregiver check-in
- [ ] Put one thing on the calendar that is only for you

At the end of 30 days you should have

A fridge sheet anyone can act on · a medication list you trust · the location of every important document · a care team with a next appointment · a home you've walked through with fresh eyes · and a weekly five minutes for yourself.

POST ON THE FRIDGE · KEEP A PHOTO ON YOUR PHONE

Emergency information

In an emergency, call 911 first. Then use this sheet.

Full name		**Date of birth**	
Address			
Preferred language		**Hearing / vision / mobility notes**	

Medical

Diagnoses & conditions			
Allergies (medications, food, latex)			
Current medications Full list in binder			
Blood type (if known)		**Pacemaker / implants / devices**	
Advance directive / DNR on file?		**Where the paperwork is kept**	

Who to call

ROLE	NAME	PHONE
Primary caregiver		
Second contact		
Primary doctor		
Pharmacy		
Preferred hospital		
Insurance (plan & member ID)		

Updated on: _____ Reprint this sheet whenever a medication, doctor, or contact changes.

WEEK 1

Care team & contacts

Everyone involved in your parent's care, on one page. Include the office's after-hours number when they have one.

ROLE	NAME	PHONE	NOTES (PORTAL LOGIN HINT, BEST TIME TO CALL, FAX)
Primary care doctor			
Specialist			
Specialist			
Specialist			
Pharmacy			
Dentist			
Eye doctor / hearing			
Home health / aide agency			
Insurance / Medicare			
Attorney / financial advisor			
Clergy / faith community			
Neighbor with a key			
Family member			
Family member			

WEEK 1 · BRING TO EVERY APPOINTMENT

Current medication list

Fill this in with the bottles in front of you. Include vitamins, supplements, and anything over the counter. Reprint when anything changes.

MEDICATION & STRENGTH	DOSE	WHEN TAKEN	PRESCRIBED BY	WHAT IT'S FOR	REFILL DUE

Allergies & past reactions

Stopped medications (name, date, why)

Pharmacy: _____ Phone: _____ Updated on: _____

WEEKLY · PRINT ONE PER WEEK

Weekly medication log

Write each medication in the left column with its time slot. Initial the box when it's given. A blank box is the fastest way to spot a missed dose.

Week of: _____

MEDICATION · TIME	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Morning							
Midday							
Evening							
Bedtime							
As needed (write dose & time)							

Missed doses, side effects, refills ordered

WEEK 3 · BRING TO EVERY VISIT

Appointment tracker

One row per visit. The last column is the one people forget, and it's the one that matters a week later.

DATE & TIME	PROVIDER	REASON FOR VISIT	WHAT THEY SAID	NEXT STEPS & FOLLOW-UP DATE

Before you leave the office, ask

Is there anything I should watch for before the next visit? · Who do I call if it happens after hours? · Did anything change on the medication list today?

WEEK 3 · FILL IN THE NIGHT BEFORE

Questions to ask the doctor

Check the ones that apply, add your own, and write the answers during the visit. Hand the sheet to the doctor if it's easier than reading it aloud.

Appointment with: _____ Date: _____

About the condition

- [ ] What is the diagnosis, in plain words?
- [ ] What should we expect over the next few months?
- [ ] What changes should we watch for, and which ones mean we call you right away?
- [ ] Is there anything we should stop doing, or start doing, at home?

About medications

- [ ] Here is the full list. Does anything on it concern you?
- [ ] What is each new medication for, and how will we know it's working?
- [ ] What side effects are common, and which ones should we report?
- [ ] Is there anything that should not be taken together, or with food or alcohol?

About care and support

- [ ] Who do we call after hours, and when should we go to the ER instead?
- [ ] Would home health, physical therapy, or other services help? Who orders them?
- [ ] Is it still safe for them to drive / live alone / manage their own medications?
- [ ] Which release form lets you talk with me about their care?
- [ ] When is the next visit, and what should we bring?

Our own questions

Answers & notes from the visit

WEEK 2

Important documents checklist

You are not creating these documents this month. You are finding out which ones exist and where they live. Names vary by state; ask the attorney or clinic for the local equivalent.

DOCUMENT	EXISTS?	WHERE IT'S KEPT	NOTES (WHO HAS COPIES, DATE SIGNED)
Healthcare power of attorney Who speaks for them on medical decisions			
Advance directive / living will Their wishes for end-of-life care			
Medical records release (HIPAA) Lets providers talk to you			
Do-not-resuscitate order (if any) Must be the state's own form to be honored			
Financial power of attorney Who can handle money and bills			
Will or trust			
Photo ID, Social Security card, birth certificate			
Medicare / insurance cards & supplemental policies			
Long-term care insurance policy			
Life insurance policies			
Bank & investment accounts Institution and last 4 digits only			
Pension, retirement, Social Security statements			
Deed, mortgage, or lease			
Vehicle title & insurance			
Military discharge papers (DD-214)			
Marriage / divorce certificates			
Funeral or burial pre-arrangements			
List of online accounts & where passwords are kept Never write passwords on this page			

AS NEEDED · ONE PAGE PER DAY

Daily care & symptom log

Use this when a doctor asked you to watch for something, or when your gut says something is off. Patterns show up on paper long before they show up in memory.

Date: _____ Logged by: _____

CHECK-IN	MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Mood & alertness			
Ate & drank			
Bathroom			
Mobility & balance			
Sleep / naps			
Vitals, if tracking BP · pulse · temp · glucose · weight			

Pain today (circle)

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Where, and what helped:

Medications given as planned?

☐ Yes ☐ Missed / late (note which):

Anything new or different today

To report to the doctor / to tell the next caregiver

WEEK 4

Home safety walkthrough

Walk through the house the way your parent moves through it: from the bed to the bathroom at night, from the chair to the kitchen. Check what's fine, note what isn't.

Everywhere

- [ ] Loose rugs removed or taped down
- [ ] Clear paths, cords off the floor
- [ ] Night lights bedroom → bathroom
- [ ] Smoke & CO detectors tested
- [ ] Emergency numbers posted (fridge sheet)
- [ ] Phone reachable from bed and chair
- [ ] Thermostat easy to read and reach

Entry & stairs

- [ ] Sturdy handrails on both sides
- [ ] Steps even, edges visible, lit
- [ ] Door locks they can work easily
- [ ] A neighbor or lockbox has a key

Bathroom

- [ ] Grab bars by toilet and in shower
- [ ] Non-slip mat in tub or shower
- [ ] Shower chair or bench if standing is hard
- [ ] Raised toilet seat if needed
- [ ] Water heater set to 120°F or lower
- [ ] Door can be unlocked from outside

Bedroom

- [ ] Lamp reachable from bed
- [ ] Bed height lets feet touch the floor
- [ ] Clear path to the bathroom
- [ ] Glasses, phone, water within reach

Kitchen

- [ ] Everyday items at waist to shoulder height
- [ ] No step stools needed for daily use
- [ ] Stove knobs clearly marked; auto-off if forgetful
- [ ] Fire extinguisher within reach
- [ ] Expired food and medicine cleared out

Medications

- [ ] One storage place, not scattered
- [ ] Weekly pill organizer if more than 3 meds
- [ ] Old prescriptions removed
- [ ] List on the fridge matches the bottles

WHAT NEEDS FIXING	WHO WILL DO IT	BY WHEN	DONE

WEEKLY · SUNDAY NIGHT · FIVE MINUTES

Weekly caregiver check-in

This page is about you. Caregivers who burn out usually saw it coming on paper weeks before they felt it. This is the paper.

Week of: _____

This week I slept

☐ Enough ☐ Not quite ☐ Badly, most nights

My own health

☐ Kept my appointments ☐ Skipped or postponed one ☐ Haven't scheduled

What went well

What was hardest

One task I will hand to someone else next week

Task, and who I'll ask:

One thing I will do that is only for me

On the calendar, day and time:

Warning signs worth taking seriously

- ☐ Snapping at my parent or family
- ☐ Skipping meals or living on coffee
- ☐ Not sleeping even when I can
- ☐ Dreading the phone ringing
- ☐ Nobody else knows the routine
- ☐ Haven't seen a friend in weeks

Three or more checked for two weeks running: that is the moment to call someone. Your doctor, a caregiver support line, your Area Agency on Aging, or the person on the contacts page you trust most.

ONGOING · THE RUNNING RECORD

Call & decision log

Every call with insurance, the pharmacy, a doctor's office, or a family decision. Date, who, what was said, what happens next. Reprint as the pages fill.

DATE	WHO I SPOKE WITH Name & organization	ABOUT	WHAT WAS SAID / DECIDED	FOLLOW-UP & REFERENCE #

Tip

Ask for a reference or case number on every insurance call and write it in the last column. It turns "someone told me" into something the next person can look up.